Reconstruction as Transformation

Photo: AIDMI.

Change as a verb

Post-disaster reconstruction policies and programmes focus on change as an opportunity and a necessity. The experience of recent losses is expected to motivate households, communities, technical professionals and governments to devise and adopt better practices. Constructing a new is expected to be an opportunity to incorporate hazard resistant measures. Disasters are expected to generate political momentum for institutional change.

Many of us involved in disaster risk management see unprecedented opportunities to advocate for and to operationalise agendas of risk reduction. Advocacy tends to focus on change as a noun; a changed end state. Operationalisation describes change as a verb, requiring consideration of the actions and actors involved. Unfortunately, most of the policies, plans, advice and opinions informing reconstruction could best be described as advocacy rather than operationalisation or realisation. They are more concerned with change as a result rather than a process.

What should change or what could change?

Our discourse of reconstruction is dominated by language of what **should** happen, what **should** change. The discourse is aspirational, idealistic and perhaps not as useful as we think. The expectations that change is necessary are insufficiently informed by analysis of the assumptions made, the risks to overcome, the sequence of actions, how to prioritise, the capacities available or needed. With so little emphasis on the means of change, we tend to stay in the realm of the **'should'** rather than **'could'.** For many technical professionals the unequivocal domain of **'what should happen'** is more comfortable than the messy, compromised domain of operationalisation, of **'what could happen',** for example: 'how to build perfect new construction' is far more comfortable and reputational risk-averse than 'how to improve substandard existing buildings'.

After a major disaster there are demands that building codes should be reviewed and revised. How will a code review process that normally takes several years accelerate enough to provide decisions in time for reconstruction? Codes require technical and political consensus building processes. Engineering questions may be the most straightforward. Mechanisms to address issues such as diverging opinions, economics and affordability, the implications of late decisions and crucially of ensuring compliance with codes, require as much attention.

Compliance with building codes is more likely in the reconstruction of infrastructure, education or health facilities where institutional funding is linked to regulatory systems, but in the majority of privately funded construction, and particularly housing, worldwide, regulatory leverage is often weak. People reconstructing houses must balance codes or prescribed standards with what is possible and what their households want. 'What is possible' in a post- disaster situation depends on the availability and affordability of materials and labour. 'What households want' depends on attitudes and values that inform housing aspirations, preferences and priorities.

Large scale housing reconstruction often involves changes in typologies, in materials, in finishes, in household services, etc. We tend to focus on reviewing construction standards, on hazard resistance criteria, but we look less at how housing may change or is already changing in response to what is possible and what people want.

What is changing and why?

It is not enough to prescribe what people should build. We need to understand what people are building, what choices they are making. We need to learn about decision–making in order to understand change. This perspective accepts that change has many drivers, underlying as well as crisis–specific, immediately apparent and emergent over the recovery period. If we aim to ensure people are supported to take informed action, whether through building codes or other measures, we should anticipate an iterative process that is continuously learning, responding to opportunities and challenges. While the majority of advocacy, policies and blogs on the changes that 'should happen', take place in the first months or year after a disaster, an iterative approach requires a very different commitment over much longer time, and does not require expert all-knowing answers from the outset but assumes a coproduction of diagnoses and answers by experts and affected populations together.

In housing reconstruction, we need to understand links between housing and livelihoods; we need to understand housing markets and societal values. Post-disaster housing reconstruction data tends to be mainly quantitative, numbers destroyed, numbers displaced, locations, values, costs. We need to invest more in qualitative data to better understand how reconstruction happens, not just to count, map or measure, but to understand.

Housing systems are made up of households. Housing is particularly amenable to research from household level, learning about the choices people make, if, how and why they adapt or change, their motivations and priorities, looking longitudinally at their reconstruction trajectories, watching change, accelerated change, change under stress, and learning from it. Qualitative research can be quick and agile, flexible and low–cost.

What we can learn is as essential for policy makers, for programming, and for supporting affected populations. Qualitative approaches help us to go beyond 'the what', to 'the why' of changes happening – to understand. ■

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